



Identifying prepositional phrasal verbs

A prepositional phrasal verb is made up of a verb followed by a preposition. This type of verb must have an object, but the preposition cannot be separated from its verb by this object. If the preposition part of a prepositional phrasal verb is removed, the sentence will not make sense.

Daisy was **annoyed and afraid of** Ed's poor cycling skills. ❌

If the phrase *and afraid* is removed, the sentence does not make sense.

Daisy was **annoyed of** Ed's poor cycling skills. ❌

This phrasal verb does make sense on its own.

Daisy was **afraid of** Ed's poor cycling skills. ✅

The correct preposition has been added into the sentence.

object, a noun phrase

Daisy was **annoyed by** and **afraid of** Ed's poor cycling skills. ✅

Using prepositional phrases

Prepositional phrases can be used like adjectives and adverbs to modify nouns or verbs. They can offer more detail about an object so that the reader knows what or whom is being referred to, or they can point to where something is, or when or why something happened.

This prepositional phrase is working as an adjective because it is describing a noun, *eagle*.

Daisy saw an eagle **in** a tree.

This prepositional phrase is working as an adverb, because it is describing where they raced.

They raced **down** a hill.

ride **with** Ed. They raced **down** and stopped **next to** a bridge.

Complex prepositions

Sometimes simple prepositions are used with one or two other words to form complex prepositions, which act as a single unit. Like one-word prepositions, these come before nouns or pronouns in prepositional phrases and can act as adjectives or adverbs.

except for **next to**
out of **as for** **in front of**
in spite of **along with**

GLOSSARY

Adjective prepositional phrase A prepositional phrase that describes a noun.

Adverb prepositional phrase A prepositional phrase that describes a verb.

Noun phrase A phrase made up of a noun and any words that are modifying that noun, such as articles or adjectives.

Object The noun or pronoun that is receiving the action of the verb.

Prepositional phrasal verb A verb followed by a preposition, which together act as a single unit.

Prepositional phrase A preposition followed by a noun, pronoun, or noun phrase that together act as an adjective (describing a noun) or an adverb (describing a verb) in a sentence.